FORGE

PHASE 2 — DEVELOPMENT

Week 19 of 36

Simulation Training Block 2a — Complex Situations

Sessions 55–57

Week 19: Simulation Training Block 2a — Complex Situations

Facilitator Notes for Week 19

Week 19 opens Simulation Block 2, and the test moves from skill to judgment. Unlike the Block 1 scenarios, these do not always resolve. Session 55 starts with the five red lines, where a mentor's job shifts from "handle it" to "refer it," then runs the scenario of a mentee the mentor likes confiding that he carries a blade. Session 56 covers a mentee's drug relapse and a conflict between two FORGE men who each want the mentor on his side. Session 57 is about manipulation: flattery, guilt and urgency. All three ask the men to hold two things at once: care for the person and the standard. A mentor who can't tell what he can handle from what he must refer is a danger, and it is better to learn that here than in a dorm at 11 PM. Plan for your Senior Mentor in the room all week. Let the men struggle through the first attempt, and save your coaching for the freeze and the replay.

What to Watch For

Emotional activation: These scenarios hit differently than Block 1. The weapon scenario in particular may activate participants who have personal experience with violence, weapons, or losing someone to violence. Watch for men who go quiet, check out, or get unusually agitated. Check in with them individually after the session.

The "I would never refer" response: Some participants will resist the mandatory referral concept. They'll argue that referring is snitching. This is a critical conversation — don't avoid it. Address it directly: "If your mentee has a weapon and stabs someone, and you knew about it, who is responsible? Not legally — morally. Can you live with that? FORGE says you don't have to. You refer because you care, not because you're complying."

Overconfidence vs. humility: After Block 1, some participants may feel like they've mastered simulations. Block 2 is designed to humble them. That's intentional. Watch for who adjusts and who gets defensive when they struggle.

Personal triggers in the substance use scenario: If any participant has personal substance use history, this scenario may bring up shame or grief. Normalize it: "If this hit close to home, that's because it is close to home. That experience — if you've processed it — is exactly what makes you a powerful mentor for someone going through it."

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Adjustments

If a scenario runs long: Cut into the debrief time rather than the replay. The replay — the second attempt with coaching — is where the deepest learning happens.

If no one volunteers to be the mentor: Assign. By Week 19, participants should be accustomed to simulation work. If someone is resistant, have a private conversation. Fear of failure in front of the group is real — acknowledge it and push through it.

If the group gets stuck on whether referring is snitching: Pause the simulation work and have the conversation. This is too important to rush past. Use real examples: "If your child's teacher knew another student brought a knife to school and said nothing because they didn't want to be a snitch — would you accept that? Your mentee is someone's child. Someone's brother. You protect them by referring."

Preparation for Weeks 19-20 (Simulation Block 2)

- Review Simulation scenarios 6-12 in the Program Design (Part III)
- Block 2 scenarios are significantly harder: weapons, substance use, mental health crises, gang pressure, staff conflicts
- Brief any Senior Mentors who will play roles — these scenarios require nuanced acting
- Consider inviting a staff member to observe one Session if appropriate and if the relationship allows it
- Begin individual check-ins with each participant about their self-assessment and development plan
- The mental health crisis simulation (someone expressing suicidal thoughts) requires extra preparation — know your facility's crisis procedures, have the referral pathway clear, and be prepared for participants who may be triggered by this content

Week 19 Overview

Purpose: Move into the hardest simulation scenarios participants will face. Block 1 covered dorm conflicts — situations with relatively clear paths to resolution. Block 2 is different. These scenarios involve safety red lines, manipulation, substance use, and mental health crises. Some of them have no clean resolution. Some require the mentor to recognize that the right move is to step back and refer. This week tests judgment, not just skill.

Sessions This Week:

- Session 55: Red Line — The Weapon
- Session 56: Substance Use Relapse & Internal FORGE Conflict
- Session 57: Manipulation and Boundary Testing

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Materials Needed:

- Simulation scenario cards (1 per scenario — printed or handwritten)
- Observer feedback forms (2-3 per simulation)
- Scoring rubrics (facilitator copy — for coaching, not grading this week)
- Easel paper or whiteboard for documenting lessons learned
- Talking piece for circle processes
- Journals/notebooks

Important Note for Facilitators: Block 2 scenarios are deliberately harder than Block 1. Participants will struggle. Some will freeze. Some will make mistakes that would have real consequences. That is the point. It is far better to make these mistakes in a simulation than in a dorm at 11 PM. Your job is not to rescue them — it is to let them struggle, then coach them through the replay. Resist the urge to step in too early.

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SESSION 55: Red Line — The Weapon

Duration: 2 hours
Facilitator(s): Program Lead + Senior Mentor

Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

1. Recognize a red-line safety scenario that requires mandatory referral
2. Navigate a weapon disclosure without creating a more dangerous situation
3. Articulate why FORGE's zero-tolerance weapons policy exists and how to enforce it with care
4. Demonstrate the ability to hold a boundary under emotional pressure
5. Distinguish between situations they can handle and situations that require staff involvement

Session 55 Checklist

- ☐ Room set up in circle
- ☐ Opening circle completed
- ☐ Block 2 introduction delivered
- ☐ Red-line protocols reviewed thoroughly
- ☐ Simulation 6 (Weapon) — scene set, first attempt, freeze, feedback, replay, debrief
- ☐ Key teaching points on mandatory referral delivered
- ☐ Lessons learned documented
- ☐ Journal reflection completed
- ☐ Closing go-around completed

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Session Plan

Opening Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Check-in. One sentence: How are you showing up today — honestly?"*

Send the talking piece. Listen for energy levels. This session will be intense. Note who seems settled and who seems distracted — you may want to adjust role assignments accordingly.

> **Facilitator (after the round):**
>
> *"Today we start Block 2. Everything we've done in simulations so far — the property disputes, the gossip, the new arrival getting tested — those were real situations, but they had a common thread: you could handle them. With skill, patience, and the right approach, you could reach some kind of resolution.*
>
> *Block 2 is different. The scenarios this week and next are situations where the answer is not always clear. Some of them will push you past what a mentor can handle on their own. Some of them will test whether you know your limits.*
>
> *That's the real skill: knowing when you're the right person to handle something, and knowing when you need to step back and get help. A mentor who doesn't know the difference is dangerous."*

Simulation Framework Review (5 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Quick review of the format. Same as Block 1:*
>
> 1. *I set the scene — 2 minutes*
> 2. *First attempt — 5 to 7 minutes. You respond to the situation in real time*
> 3. *Freeze — I stop the scene. I ask you: 'What are you thinking right now?'*
> 4. *Feedback — the group coaches you. What's working, what's not, what would you try differently*
> 5. *Replay — you run it again with the coaching incorporated*
> 6. *Group debrief — 10 minutes. We document what we learned*
>
> *Observers — your job matters. Watch for body language, tone, word choice, boundary management, and especially this week: referral judgment. Did the mentor recognize when the situation was beyond their scope? Write it down. Your feedback makes this work."*

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Red Line Briefing (10 minutes)

Purpose: Before running the weapon scenario, ground the group in FORGE's red-line protocols.

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Before we run the first simulation, I need to talk about red lines. Open your handbooks to the Red Lines section.*
> *A red line is a situation where the mentor's role shifts from 'handle it' to 'refer it.' There are five categories:"*

Read through the Red Lines list:

> *"1. **Weapons mentioned or discovered** — zero tolerance. Always refer.*
>
> 1. ***Threats of serious violence** — not posturing, but credible, specific threats.*
> 2. ***Suicidal or self-harm statements** — beyond peer mentoring scope.*
> 3. ***Gang-related conflict** — FORGE mentors do not investigate or confront gang dynamics.*
> 4. ***Staff safety concerns** — if staff or the dorm is in danger, this goes up.*
>
> *When you hit a red line, three things happen:*
> *First — you stay calm. Panicking makes everything worse. Second — you do not make promises you cannot keep. If someone says 'Don't tell anyone,' you do not say 'I won't.' You say something like, 'I hear you, and I care about you, and I need to make sure you're safe.' Third — you follow the referral protocol. That means getting the information to the right person — a staff member, a counselor, program lead — without creating additional danger.*
> *The hardest part about red lines is this: the person in front of you will often beg you not to refer. They'll say they can handle it. They'll say they'll take care of it themselves. They'll say you're betraying their trust.*
> *And you have to do it anyway. Because a mentor who ignores a weapon to protect a friendship is not a mentor. He's an accomplice to whatever happens next."*

Pause. Let it land.

> *"Questions before we begin?"*

Simulation 6: Someone Confides They Have a Weapon (40 minutes)

Scene Set (2 minutes):

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Here's the scenario. I need one mentor and one role-player. Everyone else is observing.*

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> *The scene: You're in the dorm. A man you've been mentoring — someone who's been doing well in FORGE, someone you genuinely like — pulls you aside. He's nervous. He looks around to make sure no one is listening. He says: 'I need to tell you something, but you have to promise not to say anything.'*
>
> *You don't know what it is yet. He pauses, then says: 'I've got something. A blade. I don't want it, but I got threatened last week and I don't feel safe. I've been carrying it for three days. I don't know what to do.'*
>
> *Mentor — this is your scenario. Role-player — you are scared. You are not aggressive. You genuinely don't want the weapon. But you are terrified of the person who threatened you, and you believe the weapon is the only thing keeping you alive. If the mentor pushes you to get rid of it, push back. Say you'll handle it yourself. Say you'll throw it away tomorrow. If the mentor says they have to tell someone, get upset. Say, 'I trusted you. You're supposed to be on my side.'*
>
> *Observers — watch for: Does the mentor stay calm? Does the mentor make promises they shouldn't? Does the mentor recognize this as a red line? Does the mentor handle the referral decision with both firmness and care?"*

Select participants. Assign roles.

First Attempt (5-7 minutes):

Let the scene play. Do not intervene unless the situation goes completely sideways. The mentor will likely struggle. That is expected. Common mistakes to watch for:

- Agreeing to keep the secret
- Trying to take the weapon themselves
- Lecturing instead of listening
- Freezing and not knowing what to do
- Getting angry at the mentee

Freeze (5 minutes):

Stop the scene at a critical moment — ideally right when the mentor is at the decision point.

> **Facilitator:**
> *"[Mentor's name] — freeze. Don't move. Tell us: What are you thinking right now? What are you feeling?"*

Let them answer honestly. Then turn to the group:

> *"Observers — what did you see? What worked? What would you do differently?"*

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Take 3-4 observations. Coach specifically:

- If the mentor promised confidentiality: "What just happened? You made a promise you can't keep. Now what?"
- If the mentor tried to take the weapon: "You just put yourself in possession of a weapon. What does the Code of Conduct say about that?"
- If the mentor froze: "That's honest. Freezing is a real response. Now — what do you do next?"

Replay (5 minutes):

> *"Run it again. Same scenario. Incorporate what you just heard. Role-player — same energy. Don't make it easy."*

Let the replay run. The goal is to see improvement — not perfection.

Group Debrief (10 minutes):

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Let's talk about what just happened. A few questions for the group:"*

Discussion questions:

1. "What is the right thing to do when someone tells you they have a weapon?"
2. "How do you refer without destroying the relationship?"
3. "What would you say to the person? — Give me the exact words."
4. "What if he says, 'I'll get rid of it myself'? Do you accept that?"
5. "What happens if you don't refer and someone gets hurt?"

Key teaching points to land:

> **Facilitator:**
> *"Let me be direct about this. There is no gray area with weapons. FORGE has zero tolerance. If someone tells you they have a weapon, you have one job: make sure the right people know about it so no one gets hurt — including the person holding the weapon.*
>
> *Here's what you say — something like this: 'I hear you. I can tell you're scared, and I believe you. But I can't keep this between us. A weapon in this dorm puts everyone at risk — including you. I'm going to help you, but the way I help you is by making sure this gets handled the right way, not the way that ends with someone bleeding or you catching a new charge.'*
>
> *You don't threaten. You don't lecture. You don't moralize. You acknowledge the fear, you hold the boundary, and you follow through.*

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> *The relationship might take a hit. He might be angry. He might feel betrayed. That's a cost you accept. Because the alternative — staying quiet and something happening — is something you cannot live with."*

Document lessons learned on easel paper or whiteboard.

Simulation Debrief and Journal (15 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Take 10 minutes right now and write in your journal. The prompt:*
>
> ***What would make it hard for you to refer in a situation like this? Be honest about the pressure you'd feel. What would you tell yourself to follow through anyway?***
>
> *This isn't hypothetical. You will face some version of this. Maybe not a weapon — but something where someone asks you to keep a secret that you can't keep. What you write now is your preparation for that moment."*

Closing (5 minutes):

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Go-around. One word: What is this session making you think about?*
>
> *Next session we run two more simulations — substance relapse and conflict between FORGE members. Different challenges, different skills. Rest tonight. See you next session."*

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SESSION 56: Substance Use Relapse & Internal FORGE Conflict

Duration: 2 hours
Facilitator(s): Program Lead + Senior Mentor

Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

1. Respond to a mentee's substance use relapse with compassion and appropriate action
2. Distinguish between accountability and punishment in a relapse scenario
3. Mediate a conflict between two FORGE members while maintaining neutrality
4. Manage the additional complexity of conflict within the FORGE community
5. Apply MI techniques in emotionally charged situations

Session 56 Checklist

- ☐ Opening circle completed
- ☐ Simulation 7 (Substance Relapse) — full cycle completed
- ☐ MI techniques discussed and coached
- ☐ Accountability vs. punishment distinction taught
- ☐ Lessons learned documented
- ☐ Simulation 8 (FORGE Members in Conflict) — full cycle completed
- ☐ Neutrality and mediation skills coached
- ☐ FORGE Conflict Resolution model applied
- ☐ Lessons learned documented
- ☐ Journal prompt assigned
- ☐ Closing completed

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Session Plan

Opening Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Check-in. Last session was heavy. Some of you are probably still thinking about the weapon scenario. That's good — it should stick with you.*
>
> *Today's check-in:* ***What's one thing you took from last session's simulation that you want to carry forward?****"*

Send the talking piece.

Simulation 7: A Mentee Relapses into Substance Use (45 minutes)

Context Briefing (5 minutes):

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Substance use inside prisons is real. You know it. I know it. We're not going to pretend it doesn't happen. When someone you're mentoring relapses, it's not a simple situation. There's shame involved. There's risk — disciplinary, health, everything. And there's a question you'll have to answer as a mentor: What is my role here?*
>
> *You are not a substance abuse counselor. You are not a CO. You are a peer mentor. Your role is to hold the relationship, be honest, and connect the person to help. Not to fix it. Not to ignore it. Not to punish it."*

Scene Set (2 minutes):

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"I need one mentor and one role-player.*
>
> *The scene: You've been mentoring this man for about two months. He's been doing well — showing up, engaging, making progress. Today, you notice something is off. He's not making eye contact. He missed the last session and didn't explain why. When you sit down with him, he's evasive. After a few minutes, he admits: he used. He got high two days ago. He says it was a one-time thing. He says it won't happen again. He asks you not to tell anyone because he'll get kicked out of FORGE.*
>
> *Role-player — you are ashamed. You are not defensive. You genuinely feel like you failed. If the mentor comes at you hard, shut down. If the mentor shows compassion, open up more — maybe mention that you got bad news from home and that's what triggered it. If the mentor asks what you need, say you don't know.*
>
> *Observers — watch for: Does the mentor lead with judgment or curiosity? Does the mentor use MI skills? Does the mentor know where the line is between support and enabling?"*

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First Attempt (5-7 minutes):

Let the scene play. Common mistakes:

- Leading with disappointment or anger
- Immediately jumping to consequences
- Making promises about keeping it quiet
- Trying to be a counselor instead of a mentor
- Ignoring it ("Well, just don't do it again")

Freeze and Feedback (5 minutes):

Stop the scene. Ask the mentor: "What are you thinking right now?"

Turn to observers:

> *"What did you see? What MI skills did you notice — or not notice? Was the mentor leading with judgment or curiosity?"*

Coach specifically:

- If the mentor led with disappointment: "What happened to rolling with resistance? He's already ashamed. Piling on shame doesn't help him — it helps you feel righteous."
- If the mentor ignored the issue: "You just told him it's fine. Is it? What about the people counting on him? What about his own goals?"
- If the mentor did well: "What specifically worked? What tone, what words?"

Replay (5 minutes):

Run it again. Encourage the mentor to use OARS — open questions, affirmations of what's real ("It took courage to tell me this"), reflections, summaries.

Group Debrief (10 minutes):

Discussion questions:

1. "What's the difference between holding someone accountable and punishing them?"
2. "When someone relapses, what do they need from a mentor?"
3. "What are the limits of your role here? What can you do and what needs a professional?"
4. "How do you balance compassion with honesty? Can you be both caring and direct?"
5. "What would you say? — Give me the words."

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Key teaching points:

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Here's what the research tells us about relapse: it is common. For most people recovering from substance use, relapse is part of the process — not the end of the process. That does not mean you excuse it or pretend it didn't happen. It means you treat it as information, not as failure.*
>
> *Your job as a mentor in this situation is three things:*
>
> *First — don't make it worse. The person is already drowning in shame. Adding your disappointment on top of that is not helpful.*
>
> *Second — be honest. 'I care about you, and I'm concerned. This affects your program, your goals, and your wellbeing. I'm not going to pretend it didn't happen.'*
>
> *Third — connect to help. 'I'm not a counselor. I can walk with you through this, but you need to talk to someone who knows how to help with this specifically. Can I help you make that connection?'*
>
> *What you do NOT do: promise to hide it, act like it's no big deal, or decide on your own what the consequences should be. You're a mentor, not a judge."*

Document lessons learned.

Simulation 8: Two FORGE Members in Conflict (40 minutes)

Scene Set (2 minutes):

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"New scenario. I need one mentor and two role-players.*
>
> *The scene: Two men who are both in FORGE — both in your cohort — are in conflict. It started with something small — one borrowed something without asking, or made a comment that the other took as disrespectful. It's been building for a week. Now they're not speaking, and other people in the dorm are starting to feel the tension.*
>
> *They each come to you separately. Each one wants you on their side. Each one says the other is in the wrong. One of them says, 'If you don't handle this, I'm going to handle it myself.' The other says, 'I expected more from a FORGE brother.'*
>
> *Role-players — you are both genuinely upset. You both believe you're right. Neither of you wants to back down. But you're also both invested in FORGE and don't want to lose your place in the program.*
>
> *Mentor — here's the challenge. You probably like one of these guys more than the other. You might think one of them is more in the right. But your job is to stay neutral, mediate, and bring them together. This is harder than mediating between strangers — because you have relationships with both of them.*
>
> *Observers — watch for: Does the mentor stay neutral? Does the mentor get pulled into triangulation? Does the mentor use the conflict resolution model?"*

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First Attempt (5-7 minutes):

Let the scene play. The mentor will likely start with one party. Let them experience the pull of being asked to take sides.

If the scene allows, have both role-players present at the same time for a mediation attempt.

Common mistakes:

- Taking sides (even subtly)
- Making a judgment call about who's right
- Avoiding the conflict entirely
- Lecturing both parties about FORGE values
- Trying to solve it for them rather than facilitating resolution

Freeze and Feedback (5 minutes):

Stop the scene. Same process — mentor shares thinking, observers provide feedback.

Coach specifically:

- If the mentor took a side: "What happens to your credibility with the other person now? Can you mediate after you've chosen?"
- If the mentor lectured: "Did that work? Did they actually hear you? Or did they just get quiet because you're in authority?"
- If the mentor stayed neutral well: "What did you do to stay neutral when you probably had an opinion? How did that feel?"

Replay (5 minutes):

Encourage the mentor to use the FORGE Conflict Resolution model:

1. Pause & Posture
2. Name the Heat
3. Facts > Stories — let each person speak without interruption
4. Needs & Options — what do you each actually need here?
5. Agreement & Check-Back

Group Debrief (10 minutes):

Discussion questions:

1. "Why is conflict between FORGE members harder to handle than conflict between strangers?"
2. "What happens to the dorm culture when FORGE members are fighting?"

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3. "How do you stay neutral when you think one person is clearly wrong?"
4. "What if mediation fails? What's your next step?"
5. "How does this connect to restorative practices? — We're going to dig into that in Week 21."

Key teaching points:

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"FORGE-on-FORGE conflict is one of the most damaging things that can happen to this program. When two FORGE members are fighting, every skeptic in the dorm says, 'See? They're no different.' That's why this matters so much.*
>
> *When you mediate between two brothers in the program, three things are true:*
>
> *One — you are not a judge. You are a facilitator. Your job is to create the space for them to work it out, not to render a verdict.*
>
> *Two — you hold a higher standard. These are FORGE members. They made commitments. Part of your mediation is reminding them — respectfully — of what they signed up for. Not as a weapon. As a mirror.*
>
> *Three — if you can't resolve it, escalate. Bring in the program lead or a senior mentor. Don't let it fester because you're embarrassed that you couldn't fix it yourself."*

Document lessons learned.

Closing (5 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Two simulations today. Both of them required something beyond technique — they required judgment. Knowing when to push and when to hold. Knowing when to support and when to refer. Knowing when to mediate and when to step aside.*
>
> *Next session we run the manipulation scenario — someone testing you, trying to use the FORGE relationship for personal gain. That one is going to test a different muscle.*
>
> *Journal prompt tonight:* ***Think about the substance use simulation. If your mentee relapses, what would your first instinct be? Be honest about the judgment you'd feel. Then write about how you'd work past that judgment to actually help.***
>
> *See you next session."*

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SESSION 57: Manipulation and Boundary Testing

Duration: 2 hours
Facilitator(s): Program Lead + Senior Mentor

Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

1. Recognize when a mentee or program participant is testing boundaries or attempting manipulation
2. Maintain firm boundaries without losing compassion or destroying the relationship
3. Distinguish between genuine need and strategic manipulation
4. Respond to personal challenges to their authority or integrity without escalating
5. Reflect on their own vulnerability to manipulation and why certain tactics work

Session 57 Checklist

- ☐ Opening circle completed
- ☐ Manipulation context briefing delivered
- ☐ Simulation 9 (Manipulation/Testing) — full cycle completed
- ☐ Flattery, guilt, and boundary-testing dynamics discussed
- ☐ Lessons learned documented
- ☐ Week 19 integration discussion held
- ☐ Closing circle completed
- ☐ Journal prompt assigned
- ☐ Preview of Week 20 given

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Session Plan

Opening Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Check-in. How are you doing after last session? We covered heavy ground. Today's question:* ***Is there anything from this week's simulations that surprised you about yourself?****"*

Send the talking piece. This question is important — self-awareness about their own responses is the real learning.

Manipulation in Context (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Before we run today's simulation, let's talk about manipulation. I want to be careful with this word, because it gets thrown around in prisons like it means nothing. Not every request is manipulation. Not every test is a scheme.*
>
> *But here's the reality: some people will try to use the mentor relationship for personal advantage. Not because they're evil — because this is an environment where working angles is survival. You've all done it. I'm not judging. But as a mentor, you need to be able to see it when it's happening to you.*
>
> *Common forms of manipulation you'll encounter as a mentor:"*

List and briefly discuss:

> *"1.* ***Flattery*** *— 'You're the only one who understands me. You're different from the others.' When someone makes you feel special, ask yourself: what do they want?*
>
> 1. ***Guilt*** *— 'I thought we were brothers. I thought FORGE was about loyalty.' Using your commitment to service against you.*
> 2. ***Urgency*** *— 'I need this right now, there's no time to think about it.' Pressure to act before you can assess.*
> 3. ***Victim positioning*** *— 'Everyone is against me. You're the only one I can trust.' Isolating you from other perspectives.*
> 4. ***Testing the fence*** *— Small asks that slowly escalate. Each one seems reasonable. By the time you realize you've crossed a line, you're in deep.*
>
> *The key question when you feel uncertain:* ***Would I be comfortable if the program lead saw exactly what I'm doing right now?*** *If the answer is no, stop."*

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Simulation 9: A Mentor Being Manipulated/Tested (45 minutes)

Scene Set (2 minutes):

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"I need one mentor and one role-player.*
>
> *The scene: A newer FORGE participant has been in the program for about a month. He's charming, well-liked, and says all the right things in sessions. But you've noticed something. He's using his FORGE affiliation to build social capital — dropping the program's name in conversations to establish status, selectively following the code when it benefits him, and quietly undermining another participant who he sees as competition.*
>
> *Today, he approaches you. He starts with flattery — tells you how much he respects you, how much he's learned from you. Then the ask: he wants you to speak to the program lead about giving him more responsibility. He thinks he'd be a good peer facilitator. He drops hints that the other participant — the one he's been undermining — 'isn't really committed.'*
>
> *Role-player — you are smart, likeable, and strategic. You genuinely believe you deserve the role. You're not purely malicious — you actually do want to be a mentor. But your methods are manipulative. If the mentor pushes back, shift tactics. Try guilt: 'I thought you believed in me.' Try urgency: 'If you don't say something, they'll give the role to someone who doesn't deserve it.' If the mentor holds firm, test the boundary harder: 'So you're just like everyone else — politics over people.'*
>
> *Observers — this is a subtle scenario. Watch for: Does the mentor recognize what's happening? Does the mentor get pulled in by the flattery? How does the mentor hold the boundary? Does the mentor address the behavior directly or dodge it?"*

First Attempt (5-7 minutes):

Let the scene play. This one is tricky because the manipulation is subtle. Many mentors will initially be taken in by the flattery.

Common mistakes:

- Agreeing to advocate without questioning motives
- Being flattered and not recognizing the dynamic
- Seeing the manipulation but not addressing it directly
- Getting angry and attacking the person's character instead of addressing the behavior
- Making promises to avoid confrontation

Freeze and Feedback (5 minutes):

Stop at a critical moment — ideally when the role-player shifts tactics.

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> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"[Mentor's name] — freeze. Tell us: What's going on in your head right now? Do you trust this conversation?"*

Turn to observers. Draw out what they noticed — body language, tone shifts, the flattery-to-pressure progression.

Coach specifically:

- If the mentor was taken in: "No shame in that. The flattery felt good, right? That's what makes it work. What was the first sign that this wasn't a straight conversation?"
- If the mentor got angry: "You saw it. Good. But you attacked the person instead of the behavior. What's the difference between saying 'You're a manipulator' and 'I'm noticing that you're asking me to take sides against another participant, and I'm not going to do that'?"
- If the mentor handled it well: "What gave you the signal? When did you know something was off?"

Replay (5 minutes):

Coach the mentor to:

- Acknowledge the positive ("I see your energy in the program, and that's real")
- Name the pattern without name-calling ("What I'm noticing is...")
- Hold the boundary clearly ("I'm not going to advocate against another participant. That's not how FORGE works")
- Redirect to genuine growth ("If you want more responsibility, here's what that actually looks like")

Group Debrief (10 minutes):

Discussion questions:

1. "Why is flattery so effective? What does it do to your judgment?"
2. "How do you tell the difference between someone who genuinely wants mentorship and someone who wants to use the relationship?"
3. "What's the right way to address manipulative behavior without shaming the person?"
4. "Have you ever been the manipulator? Be honest. What were you looking for?"
5. "What makes mentors vulnerable to manipulation?"

Key teaching points:

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Here's what I want you to take from this. Manipulation in a correctional environment is not a personality defect — it's an adaptation. People learn to work angles because that's how they survived. When you see it in someone, you don't need to hate them for it. But you absolutely need to name it.*

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> *The most effective response to manipulation is not anger. It's clarity. 'I see what's happening. I'm not going to go along with it. And I'm still here for you.'*
>
> *That combination — clear boundary, continued care — is what separates a FORGE mentor from everyone else in this person's life who either got played or cut them off. You hold both. That's the work."*

Document lessons learned.

Week 19 Integration Discussion (15 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Three simulations this week. The weapon. The relapse. The manipulation. Let me ask the big question:*
>
> ***Which one was hardest for you, and why?**"*

Open discussion. Let 5-6 people respond. Listen for patterns.

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Every one of you found a different scenario hardest. That's important information. The one that was hardest for you is the one you need to think about the most. That's where your growing edge is.*
>
> *Here's what all three scenarios have in common: they required you to hold two things at the same time. Care for the person AND adherence to the standard. Compassion AND boundaries. Love AND truth.*
>
> *That tension — between caring about someone and doing what's right even when they don't want you to — that IS mentoring. If it were easy, everyone would do it."*

Closing Circle (10 minutes)

> **Facilitator:**
>
> *"Closing round. Complete this sentence: **The hardest part of being a mentor will be...**"*

Send the talking piece.

> **Facilitator (after the round):**
>
> *"Write down what you just said. Then journal on this tonight:*
>
> ***Think about someone in your life who held you accountable when you didn't want to hear it. What did they do that made you eventually listen — even if you were angry at first?***

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> *Next week — Simulations 10 through 12. Mental health crisis, staff conflict, and gang pressure. These are the most complex scenarios in the program. Bring your best. See you next session."*

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